

The Purpose and Practice of Fasting

By Dn Yonnas · Fasting · Youth & Young Adults

Summary

Fasting begins in Eden: the very first commandment concerned eating. This lesson traces the shift from the original plant-based diet to meat after the Flood, explains why we fast — to return toward the original state, to purify body and soul, and to grow through self-denial — and surveys the seven fasts of the Orthodox Church.

Lesson Objectives

- Connect fasting to God's first command in the Garden
- Explain the spiritual purposes of fasting beyond food rules
- Know the seven fasts of the Church and what each remembers

Key Bible Verses

Genesis 2:16–17 — the first command about eating

Matthew 4:2 — our Lord fasted forty days and forty nights

Joel 2:12 — "Turn to Me with all your heart, with fasting, with weeping"

Main Teaching Points

- The first test of obedience in Eden involved food — fasting reverses Adam's grasping
- Fasting is a return toward the pure state of humanity before the Fall
- Fasting purifies the body and soul together; it is never mere dieting
- Suffering and self-denial, rightly carried, become perseverance and growth
- Wednesday remembers the betrayal; Friday remembers the Crucifixion
- The Church gives seven fasts as a school of the spiritual life

Key Terms

- **Tsom** — Fast / fasting — the Church's school of self-denial, prayer, and return to God.
- **Abiy Tsom** — The Great Lent — the longest and most solemn fast, preparing for the Feast of the Resurrection.
- **Filseta** — The Fast of the Assumption of St. Mary, beloved especially in the Ethiopian Church.
- **Asceticism** — Spiritual training through self-denial — for love of God, never for pride.

Discussion & Reflection

- Why is fasting about the heart and not only about food?
- Which of the seven fasts do you keep now, and which could you grow into?
- How does fasting train us to say no to other temptations?